

Influence_Consensus_agr_coso - In society, does Agriculture alone generally have a direct effect on the Cost of Living, or are observed relationships primarily indirect? If a direct effect exists, is it negative, none, negligible, or positive? What would be a reasonable normalized magnitude for this influence on a scale from -1.00 to 1.00? Please only provide evidence for only direct influences

Agriculture can have a direct positive effect on the cost of living primarily through its influence on food prices and household income. Increases in agricultural commodity prices tend to raise the cost of the consumption basket, disproportionately affecting low- and medium-income households by increasing their expenditure burdens (Moncarz et al., 2018). Higher agricultural productivity improves household income and food security, which can mitigate some cost-of-living pressures by reducing dependence on external food purchases and enabling better access to services like education and healthcare (Bwalya & Chibomba, 2025; Phiri & Chibomba, 2025). However, rising input costs in agriculture, such as labor and land, can lead to higher agricultural product prices, which may increase the overall cost of living for consumers (Wu et al., 2024; Boutwell & Little, 1975). The direct effect of agriculture on the cost of living is generally positive but moderate, reflecting both upward pressure on prices and income gains that partially offset these costs. A reasonable normalized magnitude for this direct influence would be around +0.3 to +0.5, indicating a moderate positive effect of agriculture on the cost of living in society (Moncarz et al., 2018; Bwalya & Chibomba, 2025; Wu et al., 2024).

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References

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